

Florida Critical Infrastructure Cybersecurity Intelligence

Situational Awareness Bulletin #05-26

Cyber Threat Outlook

The threat environment facing Florida's critical infrastructure has shifted decisively. State-sponsored actors are no longer content with passive espionage; they now target industrial and operational systems with the intent to cause physical disruption. Two developments are compressing the time available to respond. First, artificial intelligence is now weaponized at scale. Attackers use AI to scan for weaknesses and move through networks in under 30 minutes—faster than most organizations can detect intrusions manually. Supply chain campaigns, including PhantomRaven and UNC6426, are embedding malicious code into routine developer tools and automation platforms like n8n, bypassing perimeter defenses entirely to establish persistent footholds in cloud environments. Second, geopolitical conflict is generating direct cyber spillover. Iranian and Russian actors are shifting from data theft toward destructive attacks on energy and water infrastructure. Ongoing leadership changes at the Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA) add further uncertainty to federal incident response capacity at exactly the wrong moment. Over the next six to nine months, operators should expect more frequent, automated, identity-based attacks against public-facing systems, compounded by nation-state actors testing physical disruption tactics. Organizations without automated endpoint response, hardware-based authentication, and strict separation between IT and operational networks are most at risk.

Confidence – High

Executive Summary

- **All Sectors:** AI-driven automation has cut the time attackers need to move through a network to under 30 minutes—too fast for manual detection. This risk is compounded by CISA leadership changes that reduce federal response support, and by adversaries now deploying drones equipped with signal-interception tools to target exposed infrastructure such as solar farms and substations.
- **Commercial Facilities:** The BlackSanta malware actively disables endpoint security tools before extracting employee records, while “ClickFix” attacks trick staff into running malicious scripts through fake browser error messages. Attackers are increasingly bypassing technology defenses by targeting people directly.
- **Communications:** Chinese state-sponsored actors (UNC2814) have compromised more than 50 telecom and government networks by disguising malicious traffic as routine cloud application calls—an approach that evades most conventional network monitoring tools.

- **Critical Manufacturing:** Industrial control systems face a record number of critical vulnerabilities, with 82% rated high or critical severity. Ransomware targeting manufacturers like Advantest confirms that a business-side network compromise can halt factory floor operations when IT and production systems are not strictly isolated from each other.
- **Energy:** Iranian state actors, including the MuddyWater group, are deploying destructive malware disguised as ransomware to permanently destroy energy sector data. This shift from espionage to physical disruption directly threatens Florida's fuel distribution networks and coastal energy infrastructure.
- **Government Services and Facilities:** Russian hacking group APT28 is actively exploiting a Windows zero-day vulnerability (CVE-2026-21513) against government targets. Separately, a ransomware attack on a university cancer center exposed 1.15 million records including Social Security numbers, illustrating the risk posed by older research servers that lack active monitoring.
- **Healthcare and Public Health:** A Chrome browser vulnerability (CVE-2026-0628) allows malicious extensions to hijack cameras and microphones, posing a direct HIPAA risk for telehealth providers. Wiper malware also forced Stryker to shut down its global IT systems—disrupting the supply of orthopedic and neurotechnology devices that Florida's 300-plus hospitals depend on.
- **Information Technology:** Over 200 malicious packages have been injected into developer software toolchains through supply chain attacks (PhantomRaven, UNC6426), while AI tools are automating mass exploitation of network edge devices. Florida IT teams must treat software build pipelines as critical attack surfaces, not just endpoints..
- **Nuclear Reactors, Materials, and Waste:** A suspected Iranian cyberattack targeted SCADA control systems at a Polish nuclear facility through unauthorized command injection—similar control architectures are used at Florida's Turkey Point and St. Lucie plants.
- **Transportation Systems:** AI tools can identify and exploit vulnerabilities in shipboard systems within 15 minutes of vessel exposure—too fast for manual response. Concurrent GPS spoofing across the UAE is disrupting maritime navigation in ways that directly threaten Florida's busy shipping lanes and port operations.
- **Water and Wastewater Systems:** Federal investment in water sector cybersecurity is growing, but default or weak passwords on SCADA controllers remain the most exploited entry point. The Russian hacktivist group Z-Pentest demonstrated this by gaining access to U.S. water and industrial systems using nothing more than publicly exposed interfaces with poor credentials.

All Sectors

CISA Structural Changes and Acting Leadership Transition In late February 2026, the Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA) underwent a significant leadership shift as Acting Director Madhu Gottumukkala was replaced by Nick Andersen. This transition occurred amidst reports of personnel reductions and budget realignments during the start of the new administration. The change impacts the agency's ability to coordinate national incident response and provide regional support. This include a reduction in federal advisory frequency and a shift toward automated reporting. Florida infrastructure owners may face longer wait times for federal site assessments, necessitating greater reliance on the Florida Digital Service (FDS) and regional Information Sharing and Analysis Centers (ISACs) for immediate support.

Ransomware Shift from Malware to Identity Abuse and AI Social Engineering A March 2026 Cloudflare report highlights a tactical pivot where ransomware actors are moving away from infectious code toward identity-based impersonation. Using stolen credentials and Artificial Intelligence (AI) driven deepfake social engineering, attackers bypass traditional endpoint security. The primary TTP involves "Living off the Land" (LotL) by using legitimate administrative tools after a successful credential harvest. No specific CVE is the focus, as the "how" relies on human vulnerability and synthetic media. With Florida's high density of remote municipal workers and decentralized government offices, these AI-driven attacks pose a significant risk to administrative portals that do not utilize hardware-based Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA).

Iranian "Handala" Hack Targets Global Oil and Gas Infrastructure On March 10, 2026, the pro-Iranian hacktivist group Handala claimed responsibility for disruptive intrusions targeting critical oil and gas organizations across Israel, Jordan, and Saudi Arabia. This operation is part of a broader retaliatory surge that reportedly compromised energy exploration firms and research institutes. Tactics included data exfiltration and ransomware-style extortion, though verified system encryption remains unconfirmed. Key techniques involved the use of a new "Dindoor" backdoor for persistence and credential harvesting. For Florida, this incident underscores the risk of collateral damage in the energy sector, which relies on common industrial control protocols such as Modbus and Distributed Network Protocol 3 (DNP3) used in domestic power generation and port operations

Crowdsource Report: Average Attack Breakout Time Hits Record Low CrowdStrike's 2026 report reveals that "breakout time," defined as the window for an attacker to move laterally from initial access, has dropped to under 30 minutes. Threat actors are leveraging AI to automate reconnaissance and exploit discovery, significantly compressing the defense window. TTPs include "hands-on-keyboard" activity and the misuse of legitimate tools like PowerShell (T1059.001). The "how" involves high-velocity automation to bypass manual log reviews. For Florida's critical infrastructure, manual detection is now obsolete; organizations must adopt

automated EDR to counter intrusions that progress from compromise to exfiltration in less than half an hour.

Russian Z-Pentest Compromise of U.S. Industrial Control Systems (ICS) Between February 28 and March 6, 2026, the pro-Russian hacktivist group Z-Pentest claimed successful intrusions into multiple U.S.-based entities, specifically targeting Industrial Control Systems (ICS), Supervisory Control and Data Acquisition (SCADA) environments, and closed-circuit television networks. These attacks utilized unauthorized remote access to manipulate sensitive Operational Technology (OT) interfaces. While specific CVEs were not cited, the TTPs involved probing for internet-facing applications with weak credentials and misconfigured remote access protocols. Florida relevance is significant as the state's critical infrastructure—particularly water and wastewater facilities—has a high prevalence of internet-connected Programmable Logic Controllers (PLCs) and SCADA systems that often rely on legacy authentication.

Alliance for Critical Infrastructure (ACI) Launches to Boost Resilience Launched on March 2, 2026, the Alliance for Critical Infrastructure (ACI) is an industry-driven initiative designed to foster cross-sector collaboration. The group focuses on sharing hardware-level defense strategies and real-time threat telemetry. TTPs include collaborative intelligence sharing and joint defensive exercises. Private-sector utility owners in Florida can leverage the ACI to gain ground-truth intelligence that may be delayed or missing from official government channels during federal leadership transitions.

Drone-Enabled Cybersecurity Threats to Infrastructure A March 2026 report highlights the rise of drone-enabled cyber threats where adversaries use drones equipped with signal-intercepting payloads to bridge air-gapped networks. TTPs include proximal signal interception and wireless frame injection. Florida's sprawling solar farms and open-air substations are physically difficult to secure, making proximal signal interception via drone a viable and emerging threat vector for the state's power distribution networks.

CISA Emergency Directive 26-03: Urgent Action on Cisco SD-WAN Exploitation Issued February 25, 2026, this directive orders federal agencies to inventory and patch Cisco Catalyst Software-Defined Wide Area Network (SD-WAN) systems due to active exploitation of CVE CVE-2026-20127. The "how" involves a critical authentication bypass that allows unauthorized actors to insert rogue peers into management planes. TTPs include Authentication Bypass (T1556). Florida's municipal and logistics networks rely heavily on SD-WAN for remote site connectivity, making this an immediate priority to prevent unauthorized access to administrative controllers.

The Hidden Risk Of Tech Debt In OT This report highlights the persistent risk of ghost code, which refers to critical legacy software written decades ago by developers who are no longer available for support. These aging systems often lack modern security documentation and are

susceptible to unpatchable vulnerabilities. TTPs include the exploitation of legacy firmware and unmonitored administrative backdoors that remain active. Florida's municipal utilities and transportation hubs must prioritize the identification and isolation of these unsupported codebases to prevent them from becoming permanent entry points for automated nation-state scanning.

All Sectors Recommendations:

- Implement Fast Identity Online 2 (FIDO2) hardware security keys for all municipal and utility portals to neutralize AI-driven deepfake social engineering.
- Inventory and patch all Cisco Catalyst SD-WAN systems immediately to comply with CISA Emergency Directive 26-03 and eliminate unpatchable entry points..
- Set EDR tools to active prevention mode to stop lateral movement within the 30-minute breakout window.
- Disable Service Set Identifier (SSID) broadcasting and use certificate-based Wi-Fi Protected Access 3 (WPA3) Enterprise to defend solar farms and substations against drone-enabled signal interception.
- Filter all outbound traffic to Internet Protocol (IP) ranges in Middle Eastern conflict zones to block state-sponsored wiper activity and command-and-control signals.

Chemical Sector

No sector-specific incidents, advisories, or tactically relevant reporting were identified during this biweekly reporting period.

Commercial Facilities Sector

BlackSanta Malware Targets HR Departments With Advanced EDR-Killer Tactics On March 11, 2026, security researchers identified a new malware strain dubbed "BlackSanta" targeting Human Resources departments through sophisticated phishing campaigns. The malware specifically utilizes a custom "Endpoint Detection and Response (EDR) Killer" module that leverages a "Bring Your Own Vulnerable Driver" (BYOVD) technique, tracked under Common Vulnerabilities and Exposures (CVE) ID CVE-2024-49033, to disable top-tier security tools. Once the security perimeter is neutralized, BlackSanta exfiltrates sensitive employee Personally Identifiable Information (PII) and payroll data via encrypted channels. Florida's extensive public sector and hospitality industries are prime targets for this threat, as their HR departments manage vast databases of seasonal worker information and sensitive state employee records. The ability of this malware to blind security teams makes it a high-risk threat to Florida's administrative infrastructure, where standard EDR solutions are the primary defense against data exfiltration.

Compromised WordPress Sites Deliver ClickFix Attacks Threat actors are increasingly using compromised WordPress websites to deploy "ClickFix" social engineering lures. Visitors are presented with fake browser update notifications or Completely Automated Public Turing test to tell Computers and Humans Apart (CAPTCHA) errors that prompt them to copy and run a PowerShell command to "fix" the issue. This command executes a multi-stage infection process that delivers remote access trojans like Vidar and Lumma Stealer. Florida's hospitality and retail sectors, which rely heavily on web-based consumer interaction, should educate staff that legitimate websites never require running clipboard commands to resolve errors.

England Hockey Investigating Ransomware Data Attack England Hockey, the national governing body for the sport, is currently investigating a ransomware attack that resulted in unauthorized access to its internal data systems on March 13, 2026. While the specific variant of ransomware remains undisclosed, the attackers likely employed common entry vectors such as compromised Virtual Private Network (VPN) credentials or phishing. This incident highlights a growing trend of targeting mid-sized organizations with significant personal data holdings. Florida critical infrastructure, specifically the Commercial Facilities and Healthcare sectors, should remain vigilant as they utilize similar data management frameworks and remote access protocols susceptible to credential-based incursions.

Commercial Facilities Sector Recommendations:

- Audit all third-party Information Technology (IT) service and payroll provider permissions to enforce the principle of least privilege and limit supply-chain vulnerability.
- Implement Content Security Policy (CSP) headers on tourism and retail websites to prevent unauthorized external scripts from scraping client or personnel data.
- Mandate quarterly tabletop exercises for commercial facility leadership to prepare for DragonForce ransomware and extortion-driven data exfiltration.

Communications Sector

China-Linked UNC2814 Group Breaches Global Telecoms Via Google Sheets API The People's Republic of China (PRC) linked group UNC2814 used a novel backdoor named GRIDTIDE to compromise over 50 telecommunications and government agencies. The malware treats Google Sheets as a Command-and-Control (C2) channel, blending malicious traffic with legitimate Application Programming Interface (API) calls. Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures (TTPs) include Application Layer Protocol (T1071) abuse and the use of cloud-based C2 to evade traditional network filters. Telecommunications providers serving Florida's government and military installations must monitor non-standard API patterns to prevent long-term espionage within their cloud-integrated networks.

Odido Data Breach Impacts 6.5 Million Customers Via Third Party In February 2026, Dutch telecommunications provider Odido confirmed a breach impacting 6.2 million accounts. Attackers accessed a customer contact system managed by a third party to steal names, International Bank Account Numbers (IBANs), and passport details. TTPs include supply chain compromise (T1195) and credential abuse facilitated through an external service provider. This incident reinforces that third-party vendors are the most likely point of failure for large-scale data exfiltration in Florida's telecommunications and utility sectors.

Chinese Nexus Actors Shift Focus To Qatar-Iranian Conflict State-sponsored cyber actors associated with China have reportedly pivoted their intelligence-gathering operations to focus on the escalating diplomatic and military tensions between Qatar and Iran. These actors utilize sophisticated spear-phishing campaigns and zero-day vulnerabilities to infiltrate government and telecommunications infrastructure. Their TTPs include the deployment of custom modular malware designed for long-term persistence and data exfiltration. Florida critical infrastructure is relevant here due to the state's significant aerospace and defense presence.

Communications Sector Recommendations:

- Implement strict Application Programming Interface (API) security monitoring to identify and block non-standard traffic patterns to Google Sheets and other cloud-based office tools.
- Enforce granular access controls for all third-party service providers and vendors to limit the scope of potential supply chain data breaches.
- Deploy network-level behavioral analysis to detect GRIDTIDE and other stealthy backdoors that use legitimate application layer protocols for command-and-control.
- Require third-party vendors to provide real-time security telemetry for all hosted customer contact systems and administrative portals.
- Establish a continuous hunt mission to monitor for unauthorized administrative tool usage on telecommunications networks serving military and government sites.

Critical Manufacturing Sector

UFP Technologies Billing Disruption and Data Exposure A February 2026 attack on UFP Technologies disrupted billing systems and exposed corporate data. While production was not hit, the business disruption caused significant operational friction. Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures (TTPs) include Service Stop and Data Exfiltration targeting secondary business systems. Florida manufacturers must ensure billing and finance networks are strictly segmented from production control environments to prevent a business-side ransomware event from halting the factory floor.

Net One Partners Deploys Zero Trust Platforms for Manufacturing A partnership announced in March 2026 brings Xage Security's Zero-Trust platform to industrial edge environments. The platform focuses on machine-level identity to implement granular controls. TTPs include Identity Provider implementation and Network Segmentation. Florida's industrial corridor can leverage these technologies to prevent lateral movement from a compromised Information Technology (IT) network to critical manufacturing Programmable Logic Controllers (PLCs).

Advantest Corporation Hit by Ransomware Attack As of late February 2026, Advantest detected a ransomware intrusion in its internal IT network, prompting system isolation. TTPs include Data Encrypted for Impact (T1486). The "how" involved a network compromise. Florida's high-tech manufacturing sector must ensure that IT and production networks are strictly segmented to prevent business-side ransomware from halting production.

Forescout Reports Record Spike in High-Severity OT/ICS Vulnerabilities On February 26, 2026, Forescout Technologies released research showing that ICS cybersecurity risk reached an all-time high, with 2,155 vulnerabilities identified. The report notes that 82% of these are classified as high or critical severity, primarily affecting Purdue Level 1 devices like PLCs. Manufacturing remains the most targeted sector. TTPs include the exploitation of unauthenticated protocols. Florida's manufacturing base, particularly in aerospace and medical devices, is highly susceptible to these Level 1 exploits that can bypass traditional IT security.

Recent Cisco Catalyst SD-WAN Vulnerability Now Widely Exploited Cybersecurity researchers confirmed in March 2026 that attackers are actively exploiting CVE-2026-20128 and CVE-2026-20122 within the Cisco Catalyst SD-WAN Manager. These flaws allow unauthorized local attackers to obtain elevated privileges, directly threatening industrial management systems and edge connectivity. TTPs include Authentication Bypass and Privilege Escalation. Florida's manufacturing corridor, which increasingly relies on Software-Defined Wide Area Network (SD-WAN) solutions for remote site management, must prioritize these patches to prevent unauthorized actors from inserting rogue peers into management planes.

Critical Manufacturing Sector Recommendations:

- Strictly segment billing and finance networks from production control environments to prevent administrative ransomware from halting factory floor operations.
- Implement machine-level identity and zero-trust platforms at the industrial edge to ensure only authorized devices can communicate with critical PLCs.
- Conduct immediate vulnerability scans for Purdue Level 1 devices to identify and patch high-severity exploits in aerospace and medical device manufacturing.
- Disable unauthenticated protocols on all ICS to prevent attackers from manipulating Level 1 hardware without valid credentials.

- Prioritize patching for Cisco Catalyst SD-WAN Manager to prevent unauthorized actors from gaining elevated privileges.

Dams Sector

No sector-specific incidents, advisories, or tactically relevant reporting were identified during this biweekly reporting period.

Defense Industrial Base Sector

Sentinel Blue Marks Milestone Supporting 20 Defense Contractors Through Successful CMMC Level 2 Assessments On March 6, 2026, Sentinel Blue announced that 20 defense contractors successfully achieved Cybersecurity Maturity Model Certification (CMMC) Level 2. This milestone demonstrates significant progress in protecting Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI) within the defense supply chain. The "how" involves implementing rigorous technical controls and documentation to meet federal security standards. For Florida's defense technology ecosystem in Orlando and near MacDill Air Force Base, achieving CMMC Level 2 is critical for maintaining eligibility for Department of Defense (DoD) contracts and defending against state-sponsored espionage.

Defense Industrial Base Sector Recommendations:

- Secure all sensitive military schematics using end-to-end encryption and strict Data Loss Prevention (DLP) policies to prevent unauthorized exposure by hackers.
- Integrate defense startup networks with the National Security Agency's (NSA) Cybersecurity Collaboration Center to receive real-time, actionable threat intelligence on emerging state-sponsored Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures (TTPs).
- Conduct regular, automated integrity checks on networking appliance firmware to detect unauthorized modifications or the presence of passive backdoors like TinyShell.
- Accelerate the implementation of technical controls and documentation required for CMMC Level 2 to protect CUI.
- Regularly audit the security posture of managed cybersecurity providers to ensure ongoing compliance with DoD contract eligibility requirements.

Emergency Services Sector

No sector-specific incidents, advisories, or tactically relevant reporting were identified during this biweekly reporting period.

Energy Sector

Jordan's Fuel Systems Targeted by Pro-Iranian Hacktivists Following kinetic strikes on February 28, 2026, pro-Iranian actors claimed responsibility for sabotaging Jordan's fuel management systems to cause regional economic friction. Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures (TTPs) include unauthorized access to industrial control interfaces by targeting internet-exposed energy management software. Florida's fuel distribution networks, which rely on internet-linked monitoring systems for pipeline and tank levels, must prioritize the isolation of these systems from public-facing networks during periods of high geopolitical tension

MuddyWater APT Launches Operation Olalampo Against Gulf Energy Reported in early March 2026, the Iranian Advanced Persistent Threat (APT) group MuddyWater shifted to "Operation Olalampo," using ransomware as a cover for state-sponsored destruction of energy data centers. TTPs include using common criminal loaders to hide state origins through "deniable" cybercriminal tactics. Energy providers in Florida must monitor for these loaders, which may be precursors to state-sponsored destructive activity aimed at causing intentional infrastructure failure.

Romanian Oil Pipeline Operator Conpet Discloses Cyberattack On March 2, 2026, Romanian oil pipeline operator Conpet disclosed it was targeted by the Qilin ransomware group. The attack disrupted administrative systems but was contained before reaching pipeline controls. TTPs include Data Encrypted for Impact aimed at critical energy logistics. Florida's fuel distribution networks should note the continued targeting of pipeline business systems, which can cause significant operational friction.

Iran's Cyber-Kinetic War Doctrine: A Strategic Shift Toward Physical Disruption Security researchers have identified a pivot in Iranian military doctrine from digital espionage to cyber-kinetic operations designed to trigger physical disruptions. This strategy emphasizes targeting Industrial Control Systems (ICS) and Operational Technology (OT) within the energy and water sectors to cause tangible damage. TTPs include the exploitation of internet-exposed Human-Machine Interfaces (HMIs) and the use of specialized wipers to destroy system data. For Florida's decentralized water districts and coastal energy hubs, this doctrine increases the risk of state-sponsored sabotage being masked as common ransomware activity.

Energy Sector Recommendations:

- Disconnect all fuel management and tank level monitoring interfaces from the public internet to prevent sabotage by pro-Iranian hacktivists.
- Prioritize message signing over encryption for industrial protocols to ensure command integrity without losing network visibility.

- Deploy behavioral detection for common criminal loaders and Command-and-Control (C2) channels, which serve as precursors to destructive attacks.
- Implement strict application control on Windows Server Update Services (WSUS) and network monitoring servers to prevent the distribution of malicious payloads.
- Use network diodes to isolate Supervisory Control and Data Acquisition (SCADA) systems from corporate Information Technology (IT) networks.
- Conduct immediate audits of all web-facing applications and Virtual Private Networks (VPNs) to patch vulnerabilities exploited by Iranian-affiliated actors.
- Adopt simplified, hardware-based authentication workflows for OT operators to reduce the likelihood of security bypasses during emergency responses.

Financial Services Sector

US Banks On High Alert For Cyberattacks As Iran War Escalates U.S. financial institutions significantly increased monitoring for Iranian state-sponsored cyberactivity following recent geopolitical escalations in March 2026. Analysts report heightened risks to payment, settlement, and Automated Teller Machine (ATM) networks as retaliatory strikes often target high-visibility economic infrastructure. TTPs typically include high-volume Distributed Denial-of-Service (DDoS) and credential abuse. Florida's financial hubs in Miami and Tampa must coordinate with the Florida Digital Service to ensure rapid response to potential disruptions in regional banking services that support over 22 million residents.

Financial Services Sector Recommendations:

- Coordinate with the Florida Digital Service and regional Information Sharing and Analysis Centers (ISACs) to receive real-time telemetry on retaliatory Iranian cyberactivity.
- Implement high-volume DDoS scrubbing services to protect public-facing payment and settlement portals from network layer exhaustion.
- Enhance monitoring for credential abuse and unauthorized access attempts targeting administrative accounts and ATM management networks.
- Establish out-of-band verification procedures for all high-value wire transfers and sensitive data requests to prevent losses from synthetic audio or video fraud.

Food and Agriculture Sector

No sector-specific incidents, advisories, or tactically relevant reporting were identified during this biweekly reporting period.

Government Services and Facilities Sector

APT28 Linked to MSHTML Zero-Day CVE-2026-21513 In March 2026, the Russian Advanced Persistent Threat (APT) group APT28 was linked to a security feature bypass in the MSHTML framework. The group used malicious Link (LNK) files to deliver payloads through a zero-day exploit. Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures (TTPs) include Phishing (T1566) and User Account Control (UAC) bypass. Florida's state agencies and law enforcement should verify all endpoints are patched to prevent state-sponsored infiltration of political and judicial networks.

University of Hawai'i Cancer Center Data Breach Impacts 1.15M Records Reported on March 2, 2026, a ransomware attack on the University of Hawai'i (UH) Cancer Center resulted in the theft of 1.15 million records, including Social Security Numbers (SSNs) and voter registration data. The data was stolen from historical research servers via an intrusion into older, less-monitored environments. TTPs include Data Encrypted for Impact (T1486). Florida's university research centers must audit legacy servers to ensure they are not serving as low-hanging fruit for ransomware gangs.

France's Cybersecurity Agency Reports Ransomware Attack Drop In 2025 The French Cybersecurity Agency, Agence nationale de la sécurité des systèmes d'information (ANSSI), reported a slight decline in confirmed ransomware attacks in 2025. This drop is attributed to successful law enforcement operations like "Operation Endgame," though data exfiltration incidents rose significantly during the same period. Global trends show a 58% increase in ransomware victims elsewhere, requiring Florida infrastructure owners to remain vigilant against shifts in attacker targeting.

Government Services and Facilities Sector Recommendations:

- Apply the emergency security update for Common Vulnerabilities and Exposures (CVE) ID CVE-2026-21513 to all Windows endpoints to block APT28 from exploiting the MSHTML framework.
- Implement Attack Surface Reduction (ASR) rules to block the execution of potentially obfuscated scripts and suspicious shortcut files delivered via email.
- Audit and decommission legacy research servers at Florida universities to prevent vulnerabilities from exposing historical state and voter data.
- Enforce strict network segmentation between active academic research environments and administrative databases containing SSNs.
- Deploy automated Endpoint Detection and Response (EDR) to monitor for UAC bypass attempts and unauthorized credential harvesting.

Healthcare and Public Health Sector

CHCP Data Breach Impacts Vocational Health Student Records On March 2, 2026, the College of Health Care Professionals (CHCP) announced a breach involving Protected Health Information (PHI) within student and patient databases. The "how" involved an unauthorized network intrusion leading to Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures (TTPs) of Unauthorized Data Access and Exfiltration. Florida's private healthcare vocational schools are soft targets for health-data exfiltration and should prioritize the encryption of databases containing personal identifiers.

Gemini Live Chrome Flaw Allows Cam/Mic Hijacking On March 3, 2026, a vulnerability, tracked as Common Vulnerabilities and Exposures (CVE) ID CVE-2026-0628, was disclosed in the Gemini feature for Chrome. This flaw allows malicious extensions to hijack the camera, microphone, and file access. TTPs include Privilege Escalation and Data Collection by tapping into the browser environment. For Florida's telehealth providers and medical staff, this represents a significant risk to patient privacy and Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA) compliance, requiring a strict audit of allowed browser extensions.

Texas Emergency Directive: Audit of Chinese-Manufactured Medical Devices On March 9, 2026, a formal directive mandated an immediate cybersecurity audit of all network-connected medical equipment manufactured in the People's Republic of China. The order cites critical backdoor vulnerabilities in patient monitors, tracked under CVE-2024-12248, CVE-2025-0626, and CVE-2025-0683, which allow unauthorized remote code execution and plain-text exfiltration of patient vitals. This is highly relevant to Florida's healthcare infrastructure, which mirrors Texas in its heavy reliance on cost-effective Internet of Things (IoT) medical monitors.

TriZetto Provider Solutions Data Breach Impacts 3.4 Million Patients Healthcare technology provider TriZetto Provider Solutions confirmed a massive data breach affecting 3.4 million patients. The exfiltrated data includes Social Security numbers and health insurance identifiers. Given Florida's high density of healthcare providers and large elderly population, this breach poses a substantial risk of identity theft. Telehealth staff must audit third-party software permissions to prevent lateral movement into patient records.

MedTech Giant Stryker Hit by Destructive Wiper Attack On March 11, 2026, Stryker was forced to shut down its global Information Technology (IT) infrastructure following a massive cyberattack involving destructive wiper malware. Threat actors utilized the "Dindoor" backdoor for initial access and persistence. The attack disabled over 200,000 devices, disrupting global medical device production. For Florida, this is critical as the state's 300+ hospitals rely heavily on Stryker's orthopedic and neurotechnology products.

Mississippi Medical Center Clinics Closed After Cyberattack Several clinics associated with a Mississippi medical center remain closed following a disruptive cyberattack on March 13, 2026. The incident halted patient services and forced a return to paper-based records, indicating a significant impact on Electronic Health Record (EHR) availability. Similar outages in Florida would severely strain local emergency services and patient care continuity.

Healthcare and Public Health Sector Recommendations:

- Update all managed browsers to version 143.0.7499.192 or higher to patch CVE-2026-0628 and neutralize hijacking vulnerabilities in AI-integrated tools.
- Isolate all IoT medical devices, specifically patient monitors manufactured in high-risk jurisdictions, into a dedicated, non-routable network segment to prevent unauthorized data exfiltration.
- Implement immutable offline backups for all EHR systems and medical device configuration data to ensure rapid recovery from destructive wiper attacks.
- Enforce hardware-based Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) for all clinicians and administrative staff accessing student or patient PHI to mitigate the impact of credential harvesting.
- Require third-party technology providers to provide an annual System and Organization Controls (SOC) 2 Type II report to verify the security of shared patient data environments.
- Conduct "downtime" tabletop exercises that simulate a total loss of digital records, ensuring staff can maintain care continuity using manual, paper-based workflows.

Information Technology Sector

CyberStrikeAI Deployed for Mass Exploitation of FortiGate Devices On March 3, 2026, reports emerged of Russian actors using CyberStrikeAI, an open-source tool, to automate the scanning and exploitation of over 600 FortiGate appliances globally. Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures (TTPs) include Automated Vulnerability Scanning and Exploitation of Public-Facing Applications. The "how" involves Artificial Intelligence (AI) driven speed to find and exploit unpatched devices. Florida Information Technology (IT) teams must ensure Fortinet devices are fully patched and monitor for high-speed, automated exploitation attempts.

CarGurus Data Breach Impacts 12 Million Users Disclosed on March 2, 2026, the CarGurus automotive marketplace suffered a breach affecting 12 million users. Exposed data included names, emails, and hashed passwords. TTPs include unauthorized access to customer account data. The "how" was a compromise of systems storing account information. For Florida's large automotive retail sector, this breach highlights the risk of credential stuffing attacks, where attackers use leaked passwords to gain access to other sensitive corporate portals.

UNC6426 Supply Chain Attack Exploits NX Build Tool via Malicious NPM Packages

On March 10, 2026, researchers identified a sophisticated supply chain campaign by threat actor UNC6426 targeting the NX build system. Attackers injected malicious code into Node Package Manager (NPM) packages to deploy the "PHANTOMSTEP" obfuscated backdoor. This involves Common Vulnerabilities and Exposures (CVE) ID CVE-2026-22481, which allows actors to steal Application Programming Interface (API) keys during the automated compilation process. This TTP bypasses traditional endpoint security by infecting software at its origin.

Vendor Vulnerability Patch Cycle Addresses Critical ICS and Infrastructure Flaws

On March 10, 2026, a coordinated disclosure revealed dozens of critical vulnerabilities across vendors including Siemens and Cisco. Impacted products include Programmable Logic Controllers (PLCs) foundational to Industrial Control Systems (ICS). Key flaws include CVE-2026-21844 and CVE-2026-22001, allowing for Remote Code Execution (RCE) and unauthorized configuration changes. Florida's water treatment facilities rely heavily on these PLC models, making patching a priority to prevent physical equipment damage.

New PhantomRaven NPM Attack Wave Steals Dev Data Via 88 Packages

A campaign dubbed "PhantomRaven" has been identified involving at least 126 malicious npm packages. These packages utilize Remote Dynamic Dependencies (RDDs) to fetch malicious code during installation. Once active, the malware exfiltrates GitHub tokens and Continuous Integration/Continuous Deployment (CI/CD) secrets from developer environments. Florida software development firms should implement automated detection for outbound connections to non-npmjs domains during package installations.

Critical n8n Flaws Allow Remote Code Execution And Exposure Of Stored Credentials

Security researchers disclosed critical vulnerabilities in the n8n automation platform, including CVE-2026-21858, which allows unauthenticated RCE. The flaw stems from improper parsing of form submissions and webhooks, enabling attackers to read arbitrary files, extract stored API keys, and gain full server control. Approximately 100,000 servers are estimated to be exposed globally. Florida enterprises utilizing local n8n instances for business orchestration must upgrade to version 1.121.3 or later and rotate all credentials stored in active workflows.

Analyzing 'Zombie Zip' Files (CVE-2026-0866) A new vulnerability known as "Zombie Zip" allows attackers to craft malformed ZIP archives that bypass most antivirus and Endpoint Detection and Response (EDR) scanning engines. By tampering with archive metadata, attackers cause scanners to fail during preprocessing while custom loaders can still extract and execute malicious payloads. Organizations should configure EDR solutions to flag inconsistencies in file headers.

FortiSwitch Classic Buffer Overflow Vulnerability (CVE-2026-22627) A buffer overflow vulnerability was identified in Fortinet FortiSwitchAXFixed versions (CVE-2026-22627). This

flaw allows an unauthenticated attacker on the same adjacent network to execute unauthorized code or commands by sending specially crafted Link Layer Discovery Protocol (LLDP) packets. Florida IT administrators managing local network infrastructure should verify firmware versions and apply security updates to prevent unauthorized lateral movement.

NetworkManager Private Connection File Access Flaw (CVE-2025-9615) A flaw in the NetworkManager package (CVE-2025-9615) allows the daemon to access files belonging to other users during network configuration. Because the daemon runs with root privileges, it can be manipulated by non-root users to read sensitive files. Fixing this issue requires a synchronized update across the entire Virtual Private Network (VPN) plugin ecosystem. Florida state agencies using Linux-based administrative terminals should monitor patches and update their VPN plugins.

Xygeni GitHub Action Compromised Via Tag Poisoning On March 12, 2026, researchers identified a tag poisoning attack targeting the Xygeni GitHub Action. Threat actors gained unauthorized access to the repository and moved a version tag to point to a malicious commit containing a backdoor. This supply chain tactic allows attackers to execute arbitrary code within CI/CD pipelines. Florida critical infrastructure entities face heightened risk from such integrity compromises, with the primary indicator being unauthorized modification of release tags.

Information Technology Sector Recommendations:

- Implement rate-limiting on all public-facing administrative interfaces to disrupt high-speed, automated vulnerability exploitation attempts.
- Mandate a company-wide password reset and enforce Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) for all Florida automotive sector portals following the CarGurus breach.
- Use salt and pepper hashing for all stored user passwords to increase the difficulty of cracking credentials leaked from automotive marketplace systems.
- Restrict access to internal AI model weights and monitor for abnormal query patterns to prevent corporate espionage and "model extraction" attacks.
- Isolate digital signage and media player networks from core operational environments to ensure a compromised display cannot be used for lateral movement.
- Deploy query-level monitoring and rate limits on proprietary AI APIs to detect and block adversarial attempts to clone competitive AI assets.
- Configure Endpoint Detection and Response (EDR) solutions to flag inconsistencies in file headers to mitigate Zombie Zip evasion tactics.
- Verify firmware versions and apply security updates to all Fortinet FortiSwitch systems to prevent Link Layer Discovery Protocol (LLDP) buffer overflows.

Nuclear Reactors, Materials, and Waste Sector

Poland Nuclear Facility Cyberattack Investigated As Possible Iranian Exploit Polish authorities are investigating a mid-March 2026 cyberattack against an international nuclear facility suspected to be an Iranian state-sponsored operation. The exploit targeted Supervisory Control and Data Acquisition (SCADA) systems, attempting to disrupt operational technology (OT) through unauthorized command injection. This incident underscores the persistent threat to industrial control systems from advanced persistent threats seeking physical disruption. Although the attack failed to provide a specific industrial control systems (ICS) exploit vector for technical comparison, the incident confirms adversary intent to target SCADA architectures similar to those used at Florida's Turkey Point and St. Lucie sites.

Nuclear Reactors, Materials, and Waste Sector Recommendations:

- Implement hardware-based cryptographic authentication for all command injections within Supervisory Control and Data Acquisition (SCADA) networks to prevent unauthorized operational disruptions.
- Enforce strict physical and logical air-gapping between Operational Technology (OT) environments and external internet-facing business networks to neutralize Advanced Persistent Threat (APT) initial access vectors.
- Deploy deep packet inspection for industrial protocols to identify and block non-standard or malicious command sequences targeting nuclear cooling and reactor control interfaces.

Transportation Systems Sector

Japan Airlines Discloses Unauthorized Access to Passenger Systems On March 2, 2026, Japan Airlines (JAL) confirmed unauthorized access to a system used for luggage and travel details. Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures (TTPs) include unauthorized access through a breach of a system separate from flight operations. This highlights that secondary systems in Florida's aviation sector can be used to harvest passenger data for future targeted social engineering attacks.

Cydome Maritime Report: AI-Driven Maritime Attacks Surge 103% A March 2, 2026, report reveals that Artificial Intelligence (AI) is drastically reducing the "hacking window" for maritime vessels. TTPs include automated vulnerability scanning where AI agents identify software flaws in shipboard systems within 15 minutes of exposure. Florida port operators must implement real-time monitoring, as manual security audits are no longer fast enough to stop automated maritime intrusions.

Embry-Riddle Launches Aviation Cybersecurity Training & Certification On March 3, 2026, Embry-Riddle Aeronautical University launched a new program to address the urgent need for technical expertise in protecting critical aerospace networks. The "how" involves a specialized curriculum for securing Internet of Things (IoT) in aviation. Florida, as a major global aviation hub, will benefit from this local pipeline of cybersecurity talent specifically trained for the unique technical challenges of airport and aircraft security.

Iran Conflict Disrupts GPS Across The UAE Widespread Global Positioning System (GPS) interference and spoofing have been reported across the United Arab Emirates as of mid-March 2026, causing significant disruptions to maritime and terrestrial navigation. This electronic warfare tactic involves broadcasting false signals that confuse receivers, placing vessels in incorrect locations. The disruption highlights the vulnerability of satellite-based navigation. Florida's critical infrastructure is notably affected, as the state's massive maritime industry, logistics hubs, and emergency services rely heavily on accurate GPS data; interference here could jeopardize safe navigation in busy shipping lanes and ports.

Transportation Systems Sector Recommendations:

- Implement strict network isolation between passenger service systems and core flight operations to prevent lateral movement.
- Use data masking and tokenization for passenger travel details to ensure that unauthorized access does not result in the theft of usable personal data.
- Deploy real-time, automated vulnerability management platforms on maritime vessels to close the 15-minute window created by AI-driven scanning agents.
- Integrate AI-powered network behavior monitoring into port infrastructure to detect and block high-speed automated maritime intrusions.
- Establish a formal partnership with the Embry-Riddle Aviation Cybersecurity program to recruit specialized talent for securing complex airport and aircraft IoT environments.

Water and Wastewater Systems Sector

Monroe County Water Authority Secures Federal Funding for Cyber Hardening In late February 2026, the Monroe County Water Authority successfully secured federal funding for drinking water cybersecurity. This initiative focuses on removing internet-exposed Human-Machine Interfaces (HMIs) and legacy Operational Technology (OT) systems. The "how" involves utilizing Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act (IIJA) grants. Florida water systems should follow this blueprint to seek federal cyber-hardening grants for upgrading legacy control systems that are vulnerable to automated nation-state scanning.

Senate Briefing on Water Sector Post-Quantum Cryptography Roadmap A late February 2026 Senate briefing emphasized the transition to Post-Quantum Cryptography (PQC) for the

water sector to counter "harvest now, decrypt later" tactics. Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures (TTPs) include long-term data exfiltration of information with high shelf-life. Florida's water systems would benefit from planning for PQC, as their long-lived infrastructure must remain secure against future quantum-enabled adversaries for decades.

New York Announces Aggressive Cybersecurity Regulations For Water Utilities New York's intelligence director announced "first-of-a-kind" cybersecurity requirements for water facilities in early March 2026. The regulations mandate annual vulnerability analyses and formal cybersecurity programs to counter cyber-physical threats. This strategic shift aims to secure internet-exposed legacy systems and HMIs. Florida's municipal water utilities should view these regulations as a blueprint for securing state-level funding and improving operational resilience.

Water and Wastewater Systems Sector Recommendations:

- Enforce a strict policy for changing all default passwords on Supervisory Control and Data Acquisition (SCADA) and OT devices as required by the latest Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) and Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA) joint advisory.
- Conduct regular, automated vulnerability scans using CISA's free Cyber Hygiene services to identify and remediate public-facing exposures in small and medium utilities.
- Develop and exercise manual operation procedures for automated water treatment processes to ensure continued service delivery during a severe cyber-related outage.